

Robots

Robots, or at least the idea of robotics has captivated mankind ever since levers, pulleys and other simple machines were being combined to make life easier for everyone. Robots or more accurately automations have dominated mythology and fiction even before working models were ever built. Historical accounts of automations go back to 10 century BC China in the written accounts of Lie Yukou. However mythologies often speak of mechanical human-like servants such as those built by Greek



god Hephaestus or the infamous Golem of Jewish origin. In fact you'll be surprised to know the word robot itself means "serf labor" in Czech. The more colloquial usage of the word relates to "drudgery" or "hard work". One of the first recorded designs of a robot (as we think of it today) was sketched by none other than Leonardo Da Vinci in 1493. The sketches depict a mechanical knight capable of moving arms and sitting up.

Much later the industrial revolution gave rise to assembly line robots that were to work for performing repetitive tasks. Today you have semi-autonomous robots such as Honda's Asimo (pictured alongside). The pace at which robotics and artificial intelligence is progressing singularity may not be that far ahead. When that happens let's hope that the robots will take Asimov's three laws of robotics seriously and not massacre us.

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